



Bola Tinubu (tee-NOO-boo)

President

Federal Republic of Nigeria

Addressed as: **Mr. President** | Office held since: **May 2023**

Bola Tinubu is a seasoned political operator who is betting that his deal-making skills will eventually stabilize Nigeria's economy and restore its leadership role in Africa and the world.

▣ A Political Godfather

A former senator and governor, Tinubu has translated his control of southwestern Nigerian politics into national power. He is a mentor to many politicians and helped establish the ruling All Progressives Congress (APC), which has held the presidency since 2015 and currently controls 31 out of 36 states.

▣ An Economic Reformer

Tinubu is seeking to transform his country's economy, replicating the success he had when he governed Lagos, Nigeria's commercial capital. He has instituted major reforms, including floating the currency and removing fuel subsidies, that have been long prescribed by experts, but remain controversial and unpopular at home.

Tinubu, who is also known as Asiwaju ("champion" in Yoruba), believes he is entitled to lead his country. His presidential campaign slogan was "emi lo kan" (meaning "It's my turn" in Yoruba).

WHY THEY MATTER

Tinubu wants to attract more upstream investment and increase production, and has shown a willingness to use presidential authority to resolve obstacles holding back major projects.

▣ Unlocking Investment and Production

Tinubu has sought to make Nigeria more competitive for global oil and gas capital through fiscal incentives, shorter contracting timelines, and more predictable investment terms. In August 2026, he approved a new deepwater incentive framework intended to unlock major offshore projects.

▣ Expecting More From Investors

Tinubu expects tangible benefits for Nigeria. When he approved targeted incentives for Shell's proposed Bonga South West deepwater project in January 2026, he said they were not "blanket concessions" and stressed new capital and incremental production, strong local content delivery, and in-country value addition.

Tinubu has personally intervened to unlock stalled projects. In March 2026, he oversaw a settlement ending the long-running dispute over OPL 245, clearing the way for Shell and Eni to develop one of Nigeria's largest untapped deepwater resources.

MEETING WITH THEM

Tinubu employs a warm, engaging demeanor in meetings, relying heavily on his charisma, past record, and broad vision statements to convey his main points, rather than detailed policy positions.

▣ **Broad Vision**

Tinubu talks at a high level about his goals and values, emphasizing why his government's policies are straightforward and commonsensical based on Nigeria's importance in Africa and the international community.

▣ **Personal Appeals**

Personal relationships hold great value for Tinubu, and he may reference shared acquaintances or past interactions to establish common ground. The president often tries to impart advice "as a friend" and will stress that he and his counterpart have the same goals.

Tinubu uses uncommon aphorisms and colorful metaphors to underscore his point, warning that "a blind man [who] loves his dog is in trouble" and if "you want to wrestle with the pig, you have to live with dirt."

ON THEIR MIND

▣ **Insecurity Incidents Rising**

In late August, an armed group claimed to have abducted 600 women, children and older people from a mosque in north-central Niger State—the latest in a series of high-profile attacks. Opposition lawmakers subsequently have pressed Tinubu to deploy overwhelming force to defeat these groups.

▣ **Managing U.S.-Nigerian Relations**

The Nigerian government's relations with the United States have improved since late 2025, but prominent U.S. legislators still refuse to lift Nigeria's Country of Particular Concern (CPC) status and the U.S. military in late August announced it planned to wrap up its mission in Nigeria, withdrawing about 200 troops.

▣ **Osun Gubernatorial Elections**

Tinubu's party failed to defeat opposition governor Ademola Adeleke in gubernatorial elections in Osun State in mid-August. This off-cycle race is one of the last contests before general elections in early 2027, inevitably spurring debates about whether it is a bellwether.

▣ **Nigeria's Oil Output Hits New High**

Nigeria's crude oil production rose to its highest level in more than six years in June, as stable operations and improved pipeline reliability boosted output. It pumped an average of 1.56 million barrels per day of crude oil, above the 1.5 million bpd quota allocated by OPEC.

NETWORK

Tinubu is seeking to redirect U.S. President Trump's false narrative about Christian persecution into greater security cooperation, while continuing to press UK, European, Gulf, and Chinese governments and investors to support his economic agenda.

In response to President Trump's threat to deploy the U.S. military "guns-a-blazing" to address allegations of Christian persecution, Tinubu deployed his team to engage with senior U.S. policymakers in late 2025 as well as hired a lobbying firm. Tinubu claims his government worked with the United States to plan and execute military strikes on Christmas day and against a senior ISIS leader in May 2026.

Tinubu has cultivated an extensive network of political allies, business elites, and technocrats across Nigeria, particularly in the southwest. He maintains strong ties to loyal politicians who depend on his patronage, but also is quick to make amends with former foes.

Tinubu has installed his closest associates in economic positions, including Central Bank Governor Yemi Cardoso and Minister of Solid Minerals Dele Alake. He also trusts his Chief of Staff Femi Gbajabiamila.

CONTROVERSIES

Tinubu's presidency has been shadowed by a web of controversies that have followed him throughout his political career. Moreover, his economic reforms have spurred nationwide protests.

▣ Corruption Allegations

Critics have long accused Tinubu of amassing wealth through opaque business dealings and political kickbacks. There has been scrutiny around his son Seyi's London property, which was purchased through an offshore company.

▣ Health Status and Foreign Travel

Questions about Tinubu's health have intensified, fueled by frequent trips abroad. By May 2026, he had made 51 international trips, spending more than 50 days across twelve visits to France since taking office. Critics allege these trips are for medical treatment; the presidency maintains they are working visits and vacations.

Tinubu has been dogged by questions about his time in the United States, including whether he possessed a fraudulent diploma from Chicago State University in 1979 and allegations about his involvement in drug trafficking in the 1990s.

CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- ▣ **President**, Federal Republic of Nigeria (2023 to present)
- ▣ **Co-Founder**, All Progressives Congress (APC) (2013)
- ▣ **Governor**, Lagos State (1999-2007)
- ▣ **Senator (Representing Lagos West)**, Nigerian Senate (1992-1993)
- ▣ **Accountant**, Arthur Andersen, Deloitte, and Mobil (1980s)

BIO

Tinubu's personal and professional life mirrors the multicultural, entrepreneurial, and boisterous ethos of Lagos. Born on March 29, 1952, Tinubu's mother was a renowned trader and his wife is a former senator and ordained minister. While he is Muslim, they have raised their six children as Christian; one of his sons died of cardiac arrest at age 37.

- ▣ **Formative Years in Chicago**

Tinubu worked as a security guard, taxi driver, and dishwasher, while earning a degree in accounting from Chicago State University in 1979. He worked for Deloitte and Arthur Andersen before returning home.

- ▣ **Democracy Activism in Nigeria**

Tinubu became a member of the pro-democracy group, the National Democratic Coalition (NADECO), to fight military rule in the 1990s. He was briefly jailed before going into exile in 1994.

Tinubu speaks Yoruba and English fluently, and enjoys watching football, especially when the Super Eagles, Nigeria's national football team, are on the pitch.